The Authorised Translations (Central Laws) Act of 1973 lays down that a translation in any regional language specified in the Eight Schedule to the Constitution (other than Hindi) of any central act, ordinance, order, rule, regulation and bylaw published under the authority of the President in the Official Gazette is deemed to be the authoritative texts thereof in such language.

SPECIAL DIRECTIVES

The Constitution contains certain special directives to protect the interests of linguistic minorities and to promote the development of Hindi language. There are:



Protection of Linguistic Minorities

In this regard, the Constitution makes the following provisions:

1. Every aggrieved person has the right to submit a representation for the redress of any grievance to any officer or authority of the Union or a state in any of the languages used in the Union or in the state, as the case may be. This means that a representation cannot be rejected on the ground that it is not in the official language.

2. Every state and local authority in the state should provide adequate facilities for instruction in the mother-tongue at the primary stage of education for the children belonging to linguistic minority groups. The President can issue necessary directions for this purpose[4].

3. The President should appoint a special officer for linguistic minorities to investigate all matters relating to the constitutional safeguards for linguistic minorities and to report to him/her. The President should place all such reports before the Parliament and send to the state government concerned[5].



Development of Hindi Language

The Constitution imposes a duty upon the Centre to promote the spread and development of the Hindi language so that it may become the *lingua franca* of the composite culture of India.

Further, the Centre is directed to secure the enrichment of Hindi by assimilating the forms, style and expressions used in hindustani and in other languages specified in the Eighth Schedule and by drawing its vocabulary, primarily on Sanskrit and secondarily on other languages.

At present, the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution specifies 22 languages (originally 14 languages). These are Assamese, Bengali, Bodo, Dogri (Dongri), Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Kashmiri, Konkani, Mathili (Maithili), Malayalam, Manipuri, Marathi, Nepali, Odia[6], Punjabi, Sanskrit, Santhali, Sindhi, Tamil, Telugu and Urdu. Sindhi was added by the 21st Amendment Act of 1967; Konkani, Manipuri and Nepali were added by the 71st Amendment Act of 1992; and Bodo, Dongri, Maithili and Santhali were added by the 92nd Amendment Act of 2003.

In terms of the Constitutional provisions, there are two objectives behind the specification of the above regional languages in the Eighth Schedule:

1. the members of these languages are to be given representation in the Official Language Commission; and